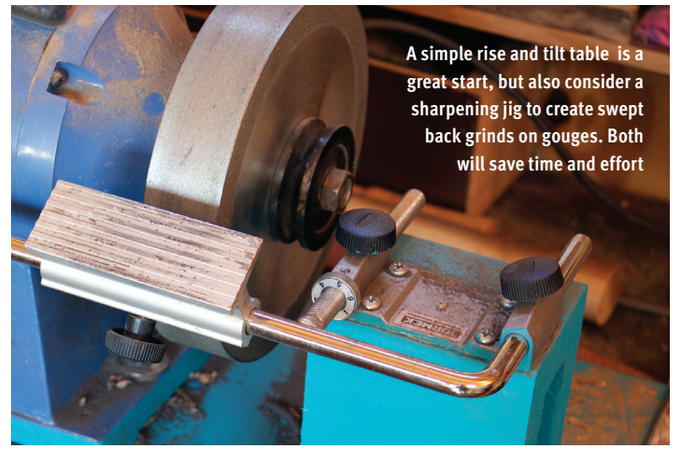
Sharpening

There are no 'absolute grinds and angles' for turning tools, although some will claim there are, but there are some common shapes that will help. Few tools come from manufacturers fully sharp. However, many manufacturers provide tools with a 'functional grind' but not all. Invariably you are likely to shape the cutting edges to your own preferences when you're more proficient with tool use.

Turning tools shift a lot of wood and need sharpening often, so a grinder with both fine and coarse wheels is essential. CBN wheels might be expensive, but are the way to go in my opinion as they grind cooler than friable wheels and never change shape so you never have to reset a grinding jig. But, there are very good aluminium oxide wheels at a far cheaper price that do a good job too. You need a 36 grit wheel for reshaping tools and a finer 80 grit or so for sharpening tools. To make sharpening easier, invest in a grinding jig and platform rest.



A simple rise and tilt table is a great start, but also consider a sharpening jig to create swept back grinds on gouges. Both will save time and effort

Ancillary stuff

You can measure and layout using only a ruler and pencil, but a few pairs of callipers and dividers will make life a lot easier. In the photo below you can see my collection of measuring tools. The silver double-ended and black callipers help ascertain the thickness of a bowl wall; the dividers are ideal for marking circles and laying out diameters for chucks.

As well as good overall lighting, it's handy to have a bright spotlight that can be adjusted all around the lathe. Strong light casts shadows that help you discern the smoothness of curves.

Whatever type of work you do, spare eyes are still in short supply, so eye protection is absolutely essential. Safety glasses come in all shapes and types, so you should be able to find something to suit you.

However, an even better option is to use an impact resistant face-shield. No matter how careful you are and how many precautions you take, one day wood will fly off the lathe and you could sustain serious injuries. In my 45 years of turning I've needed stitches on at least five occasions. It pays to minimise the risk.

Dust is a major health and fire hazard in the workshop: you should do all you can to limit your exposure to it. A small dust extractor can remove most fine dust coming off the job if you have intakes both sides of the headstock. Heavier shavings are best shovelled into a bag for removal or vacuumed up.

In addition to at-source extraction, you should wear a dust mask, even when clearing up. However, these can fog your glasses, so the best option is to use a powered respirator.

Dust extraction can easily be the most expensive item in your workshop, but it's well worth the investment.

Callipers and dividers are handy accessories to have in the workshop

Tuition

If you go on to make bigger items a lathe with a swing of 450–600mm diameter faceplate capacity and with tailstock support that accepts around 700mm between centres is ideal. Some lathes now allow the tailstock to be swung clear when not required and have moveable on/off switches, or in this case a red bar, that enables you to turn the lathe off even when both hands are occupied

When I took up turning, for three months I was lucky enough to have Rendal Crang across the workshop, churning out bowls for Douglas Hart. I'd paid to be there and the workshop sold everything I made that was up to standard. There were very few woodturners in the early 1970s, so after that it was the school of hard knocks, literally, as I entered my own apprenticeship and learned from my misadventures. Today it's easy to find help that'll get you started. Connect with your local woodworking or woodturning club or start your own, and keep a look out for hands-on workshops and symposiums, any of which can teach you the most unexpected things. Then there's the mixed blessing of the Internet 'woodturning gurus', many of whom seem woefully ignorant of how much they don't know. And finally there are quite a few very informative books and DVDs made by professional turners, several of which I'm happy to recommend even though I have my own to sell. ●

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